



KULDEEP YADAV'S DOUBLE BREAK

Kuldeep had a point to prove heading into the Champions Trophy final. Having drawn a blank in the semifinal against Australia, questions were raised regarding his big-game temperament. Both in the 2023 ODI World Cup and the 2024 T20 World Cup finals, Kuldeep had delivered uninspiring spells.

But, on Sunday, the left-arm wrist spinner altered the course of the game with the wickets of Rachin Ravindra and Kane Williamson

Rachin had started the game in a hurry, slashing and flicking the Indian pacers with aplomb, racing to 37 at the end of the PowerPlay.

He was threatening to race to his third hundred of the tournament when Kuldeep struck gold with his first ball of the day. The Indian spinner went with a googly first up, cramping Rachin for room and castling him.

Kuldeep struck again in his next over, deceiving Williamson with his dip to pouch an easy return catch. It was a match-up outcome India had hoped would unfold — Williamson's average of 26.20 in ODIs against left-arm wrist spin is his lowest against any bowling type.

By removing New Zealand's centurions from the semifinal, Kuldeep put the opposition on the backfoot.



NEW ZEALAND'S MIDDLE-OVER STEP DOWN

New Zealand lost its third wicket in the 13th over, bringing together Daryl Mitchell and Tom Latham in the middle. With Indian spinners taking control, the Kiwis went into a shell.

After scoring 6.90 RPO in the opening PowerPlay, New Zealand mellowed down in the middle overs. It recorded 3.20, 3.40 and 3.70 RPOs in the next three 10-over phases of its innings, as it prioritised seeing off the Indian spin threat.

Mitchell scored his slowest ODI fifty, and his strike rate of 62.37 was the lowest for an innings where he has faced at least 50 deliveries.

Moreover, New Zealand's cautious approach didn't pay off as it lost Mitchell and Glenn Phillips before they could take on the Indian pacers at the death. It was only thanks to Michael Bracewell's counterattacking fifty that New Zealand could reach a par score.

If the New Zealand middle-order had risked attacking one of the Indian spinners and succeeded, Hardik Pandya, who was tonked for 30 runs in three overs, would have been forced to bowl more overs.